

LOW ACID FOODS



Tweens (10–14)

Q

Why do low acid foods like vegetables and meats need to be processed in a pressure canner?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because harmful bacteria can grow if not heated enough

FUN FACT

Pressure canners reach higher temperatures than boiling water to keep food safe!

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What happens if you try to can low acid foods using a boiling water canner?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

The food could spoil and be unsafe to eat

FUN FACT

Boiling water canners only get to 212°F, but pressure canners can reach 240°F!

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What is the first step when using a pressure canner to preserve low acid foods?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Vent steam from the canner for 10 minutes before pressurizing

FUN FACT

Venting steam helps remove air, making the canning safer!

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

Which gauge type can you find on a pressure canner that needs to be monitored closely?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Dial gauge that shows pressure in pounds per square inch

FUN FACT

A dial gauge looks like a clock and tells you the exact pressure!

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans



Q

What is a weighted gauge on a pressure canner?

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ANSWER

A weight that jiggles or rocks to maintain the correct pressure

FUN FACT

The weighted gauge moves to keep the pressure steady like a little dance!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

Why must you adjust pressure in a pressure canner if you live in a high-altitude area?

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ANSWER

Because water boils at a lower temperature at higher altitudes

FUN FACT

At higher places, water boils cooler so you need more pressure to cook safely!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What pressure should you use in a dial gauge pressure canner to safely can low acid foods at sea level?

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ANSWER

**11 pounds per square inch
(psi)**

FUN FACT

11 psi gets the canner super hot to kill dangerous bacteria!

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How long should you process beans in a pressure canner at 11 psi?

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ANSWER

Pints for 65 minutes, quarts for 75 minutes

FUN FACT

Longer heating means safer food stored in your jars!

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Q

What should you do after pressure canning before opening the canner lid?

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ANSWER

Wait 5 to 10 minutes for pressure to drop to zero

FUN FACT

Pressure dropping slowly keeps the jars safe and prevents explosions!

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Q

What equipment should be placed at the bottom of a pressure canner before processing?

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ANSWER

A rack to keep jars off the bottom

FUN FACT

The rack stops jars from touching the hot canner bottom and breaking!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

When altitude is above 2,000 feet, what is the pressure for dial gauge canners to keep canned beans safe?

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ANSWER

12 pounds psi or more

FUN FACT

Altitude changes the pressure needed to keep foods safe and tasty!

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Q

What is the safest way to open a pressure canner after processing low acid foods?

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ANSWER

Unfasten the lid and tilt it away from your face

FUN FACT

Tilting the lid keeps hot steam from burning your face!

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Q

Why is it important to not retighten jar bands if they become loose after processing?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because retightening can break the seal and let in bacteria

FUN FACT

Let sealed jars cool and check the seal before touching the bands!

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Q

Why do recipes for low acid foods often include a meat piece like ham or bacon in jars?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

To add flavor and keep beans moist during canning

FUN FACT

A tiny meat cube makes homemade beans super tasty and juicy!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What is the purpose of venting steam for 10 minutes at the start of pressure canning?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

To remove air pockets so temperature is accurate

FUN FACT

Taking out air lets the canner heat jars safely and evenly!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What should you do if your pressure canner's weighted gauge jiggles very fast during processing?

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ANSWER

Lower the heat to maintain a slow, steady jiggle

FUN FACT

A steady jiggle means just the right pressure inside the canner!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

Why is it important to never stack jars inside a pressure canner?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because jars could break from shifting during processing

FUN FACT

Keep jars side by side so they all get heated safely!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What temperature does water boil at inside a pressure canner at 11 psi?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

About 240°F (116°C)

FUN FACT

Higher pressure means higher boiling temperature and safer food!

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

What is the right way to adjust jar lids before starting pressure canning?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

**Screw bands fingertip
tight-not too loose or too tight**

FUN FACT

*Fingertip tight lets air escape but
keeps the jar sealed!*

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Tweens (10–14)

Q

Why should water always cover jars by at least 1 inch when processing in a pressure canner?

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Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

To make sure jars heat evenly and safely

FUN FACT

Water covers jars so heat cooks food inside properly!

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans